decided to translate the authentic books of the different groups into another language, so that both groups could have the pleasure of benefitting from the perfect knowledge; thus forgetting their enmity and hostility and seeking the divine truth… Therefore,' continued Abu'l Fazl, 'it is an important task to translate the Mahabharata, which is about the many skills of kings and covers many principles, including the smaller issues and beliefs of India.' In this way, argued Abu'l Fazl in his preface, sulh kul would be encouraged because Muslims would become familiar with an ancient system of thought and Hindus would have to confront certain inconsistencies in the text so that, in an ideal world, one of 'complete civility', everyone might be brought to reflect individually on the nature of truth.

There were other Sanskrit texts which were translated over the next few years including the Ramayan, the *Rajatarangini*, and the story of Nala and Damayanti but the Mahabharat would remain the most popular, the most extensively studied and the most recopied over the following decades. The royal family and the Mughal elite were the main audience as well as the patrons of these works. Hamida Banu, a renowned patron, also owned a priceless copy of the Persian Ramayan. Some of the Hindus at court, especially the Rajputs, became patrons as they had had to learn Persian to occupy administrative positions. This would lead to a unique strand of Indo-Persian literature coming into existence which was all the more remarkable for it was the Brajbhasha texts that were at that time blazing through central and north India, dispersed through the mysticism of the Bhakti saints.

The Mahabharat was considered by the Mughals, as indeed by earlier rulers, as 'the most authoritative, important, and comprehensive book (among the Brahmans of India)'. Badauni mentioned an additional reason for Akbar wishing to translate the Mahabharat, one that most Hindus would be familiar with, that 'the Hindu unbelievers consider it a great religious merit to read and to copy it. And they keep it hid from Musalmans.' Therefore, Badauni argued, to accrue religious merit and glory in the world, Akbar decided to have the texts translated in his name.

Because there were no scholars who were fluent in both Sanskrit and Persian, the Mughal Mahabharat was a collaborative effort between a number of Persian and Sanskrit intellectuals. The Persian translation group included the court historian Naqib Khan, the poet Mullah Shari, a fiscal administrator Sultan Thanesari, and Badauni. The Sanskrit scholars were